When Roger Federer first won Wimbledon in 2003, he was a goofy Metallica-loving kid with a glorious game. It was the beauty of that game, the dashing ease of it, that the advertisers latched on to, that led to the creation of 'Roger Federer', the tennis champion who alighted from his soft-top Mercedes onto Centre Court, shucked off his cardigan and his Rolex and sliced some hapless plebeian opponent to ribbons, barely pausing to say "en garde".

The advertising narrative, the inanities of Nike, Rolex et al, reduced the brutal but fragile verve of Federer's game into shorthand for the plutocratic good life, the athlete-as-CEO. They took Federer's gift and somehow buffed and polished it until they achieved the most prosaic, the dullest of dull sheens.

So it's not director Asif Kapadia's fault that the new Amazon Prime documentary, *Federer: Twelve Final Days*, feels like just more buffing and like product placement for The Laver Cup, a quasi-exhibition match between Team Europe and Team World that is Federer's brainchild and partly run by his management company. Federer's image—the smooth, genial executive living a friction-free life—continues to generate millions of dollars, making him one of the world's 10 highest-earning athletes even now, nearly two years after retirement and six years after he last won a Slam.

Kapadia's co-director is Joe Sabia, who is behind Vogue's 73 Questions series, one of those celebrity trifles that purports to be fun and irreverent while treating celebrity with a seriousness that borders on worship. Federer's own 73 Questions episode is amongst the most popular in the series' history. In keeping with the advertorial nature of this documentary, Anna Wintour, *Vogue*'s desiccated grande dame, is described as Federer's 'greatest fan'.

Before the documentary was made available on Amazon Prime on June 20, I spoke to Kapadia on a Zoom call. I confessed to being surprised that Kapadia, who has made documentaries on the Formula 1 driver Ayrton Senna, the troubled pop star Amy Winehouse and Diego Maradona, would choose Federer as a subject. What could be the narrative arc in a film about the world's most well-adjusted superstar athlete?

Diego Maradona, the documentary Kapadia made in 2019, was, like its subject, kinetic and freewheeling, all madcap brilliance and Faustian tragedy. Kapadia, finding a huge amount of archival footage, focused on a small slice of Maradona's life, his time at Napoli, to illuminate the whole. *Federer: Twelve Final Days* does something similar, zeroing in on the eponymous days from his announcement of his re-

WHAT RESCUES FEDERER FROM TEDIUM IS THE PRESENCE OF NADAL, HIS ENTRY TIMED LATE FOR DRAMATIC EFFECT. HIS GRIEF OVER FEDERER'S RETIREMENT IS THE BEATING HEART OF THE DOCUMENTARY

